Introduction to Linguistics
LING 1600, Fall 2026, 3 Units

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Office hours: Mondays, 12:00–1:00pm or by appointment

Time and Place

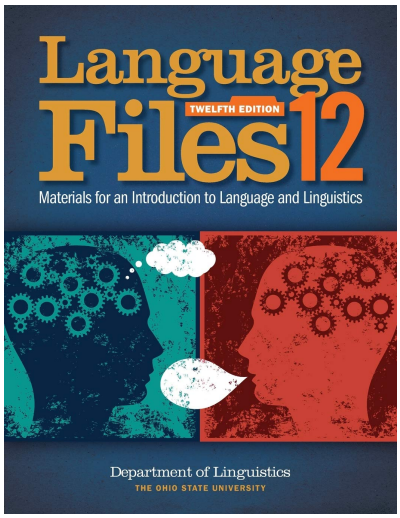
Lectures: In person, Mon & Wed, 10:00 – 11:20am, January Hall, Rm. 110

Fall classes: Monday, August 24th – Monday, December 7th

There is no Final for this course!!! HW4 is due 12/14

Required Text

Language Files, 12th edition. (2016). The Ohio State University Press. Note that this is **not** the most recent version. Please check Canvas for the availability of this book. Any additional readings are posted as PDFs as necessary.



Course Description and Learning Goals

Language is one of the fundamental capacities of the human species, and there are many interesting and meaningful ways in which it can be studied. This course explores the core components of linguistic theory: speech sounds (phonetics and phonology), word formation (morphology), sentence structure (syntax), and meaning (semantics). It also provides an overview of interdisciplinary ideas and research on how language is acquired and processed, its relation to the mind-brain and to society, and the question of whether the essential properties of language can be replicated outside the human mind (specifically, in chimpanzees or computer programs).

- Learn to view natural language, and humanity's capacity for it, as an object of scientific inquiry
- Understand the core subfields within linguistics: phonetics, phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics, and computational linguistics
- Implement methodology within these subfields
- Analyze and solve problems in novel natural language data
- Apply tools to critique and debunk common myths about language

Course Prerequisites: None

Requirements

Attendance: I will **not** take attendance. However, much of the content relevant to succeed in the course will be provided by way of the lectures, and quizzes will take place in class and are unable to be made up without prior approval from me. In short, you won't do well if you don't come to class.

Quizzes: There will be 14 quizzes which will be administered randomly in class throughout the semester. These are spot-checks on course content, and anything covered prior to the quiz could appear.

Homework: There will be 4 assignments to complete throughout the course. They are rather involved, so don't wait until the last few days to begin! You may work on these in groups or consult with your classmates (and are encouraged to do so!), but the write-ups must be done individually.

Grading Policy: The two lowest quiz grades will be dropped. *Quizzes cannot be made up* without prior email-written approval from me *before* the quiz

takes place, so *go to class!* Assignments should be turned in by 11:59pm on the due date given. Assignments will be graded within roughly 48 hours of this due date, and any assignments turned in after grading has taken place will not be accepted, unless prior email-written approval is given.

Final Grade Breakdown:

Requirement	**% of final grade**
Quizzes (12 x 4% ea.)	48%
Homeworks (4 x 13% ea.)	52%

Course Schedule (Subject to Updates)

Readings should be completed before the class meeting of the day they are listed. For example, LF12 Ch.1 should be read before the class meeting time on 08/26.

Week 1: Fundamentals

Mon 08/24	Course overview and fundamentals	
Wed 08/26	Fundamentals: Design features	LF12 Ch.1

Week 2: Phonetics I

Mon 08/31	Speech and Consonants	
Wed 09/02	Vowels and suprasegmentals	LF12 Ch.2

Week 3: Phonetics II

Mon 09/07	No class (Labor Day)	
Wed 09/09	Acoustic phonetics	

Week 4: Phonology I

Mon 09/14	Contrast	LF12 Ch.3
Wed 09/16	Phonotactics	

Week 5: Phonology II

Mon 09/21	Phonemes and allophones	
Wed 09/23	Phonological rules and processes	

Week 6: Morphology I

Mon 09/28	Introduction to morphology	LF12 Ch.4
Wed 09/30	Morphological classification	**HW1 DUE**

Week 7: Morphology II

Mon 10/05	No class (Fall Break)	
Wed 10/07	Morphology practice	

Week 8: Syntax I

Mon 10/12	Introduction to syntax	LF12 Ch.5
Wed 10/14	Grammaticality judgments/constituency	

Week 9: Syntax II

Mon 10/19	Syntactic trees	
Wed 10/21	Arguments and adjuncts	**HW2 DUE**

Week 10: Syntax III

Mon 10/26	Syntax practice and review	
Wed 10/28	Catch up day	

Week 11: Semantics & Pragmatics I

Mon 11/02	Semantics: Meaning	LF12 Ch.6
Wed 11/04	Propositions and entailment	

Week 12: Semantics & Pragmatics II

Mon 11/09	Semantics practice	**HW3 DUE**
Wed 11/11	Pragmatics: Meaning in context	LF12 Ch.7

Week 13: Semantics & Pragmatics III

Mon 11/16	Inference and implicature	
Wed 11/18	Catch up day	

Week 14: Psycholinguistics

Mon 11/23	Language & the Brain	LF12 Ch.9
Wed 11/25	No class (Thanksgiving Break)	

Week 15: Computational Linguistics I

Mon 11/30	Automatic Speech Recognition	LF12 Ch.16
Wed 12/02	Text to Speech	

Week 16: Computational Linguistics II

Mon 12/07	Large Language Models	
Wed 12/09	No class (Reading Day)	

HW4 DUE Mon, 12/14

Academic Integrity

In all academic work, the ideas and contributions of others (including generative artificial intelligence) must be appropriately acknowledged and work that is presented as original must be, in fact, original. You should familiarize yourself with the appropriate academic integrity policies of your academic program(s). For more details, see:

- WashU Academic Integrity Policy
- Guide to citing sources

Unauthorized recording/distribution of classroom activities and materials

The following applies to all students: "Except as otherwise expressly authorized by the instructor or the university, students may not record, stream, reproduce, display, publish or further distribute any classroom activities or course materials. This includes lectures, class discussions, advising meetings, office hours, assessments, problems, answers, presentations, slides, screenshots or other materials presented as part of the course. If a student with a disability wishes to request the use of assistive technology as a reasonable accommodation, the student must first contact the Office of Disability Resources to seek approval. If recording is permitted, unauthorized use or distribution of recordings is also prohibited."

Disability Resources

WashU supports the right of all enrolled students to an equal educational opportunity and strives to create an inclusive learning environment. In the event a physical or online environment, learning activity, or learning interaction results in barriers to your inclusion due to a disability, please contact WashU's Disability Resources (DR) to engage in a process for determining and communicating approved accommodations. As soon as possible after receiving an accommodation from DR, send me your WashU Accommodation Letter. Because accommodations are not applied retroactively, initiate your request to DR prior to, or at the beginning of, the academic term to avoid

delays in accessing accommodations once classes begin: disability.washu.edu

Sexual Harassment & Assault

If you are a victim of sexual discrimination, harassment or violence, we encourage you to speak with someone as soon as possible. Understand that if you choose to speak to me as an instructor, I must report your disclosure to my department chair, dean, or the Title IX Compliance Officer, which may trigger an investigation into the incident. You may also reach out to the Relationship & Sexual Violence Prevention (RSVP) Center to discuss your rights and your options with individuals who are not mandatory reporters. https://titleix.wustl.edu/students/confidentiality-resources-support/

Religious Holidays

To ensure that accommodations may be made for students who miss class, assignments, or exams to observe a religious holiday, you must inform me in writing before the end of the third week of class, or as soon as possible if the holiday occurs during the first three weeks of the semester. For more information, please see the university's Religious Holiday Class Absence Policy.

Emergency Preparedness

Classroom/student safety will always come first. Students are reminded to review emergency preparedness and response actions at emergency.washu.edu and to familiarize yourself with the building(s) that you frequent. Know the layout, including exits, stairwells and the Emergency Assembly Point (EAP). If an emergency occurs during class, we will stop instruction, assess the situation, and respond accordingly, including following any instructions provided in a WashU Alert message or noted on emergency.washu.edu. Additionally, to ensure receipt of all WashU Alerts, students should ensure contact information in Workday Student is current and download the WashU Safe App.

To report an emergency:
Danforth Campus – (314) 935-5555
School of Medicine Campus – (314) 362-4357
North/West/South and Off Campus – 911 then (314) 935-5555

Resources for Students

WashU provides a wealth of support services that address academic, personal, and professional needs. To start exploring resources that can help you along the way, please visit: Resources for Students.